

Over the course of my college experience I have taken many different types of classes. Most of them are engineering core classes and while I am thankful for them, I believe a large amount of appreciation was gained from my general education courses. Over my time at Iowa State University, several different general education requirements have stuck out to me for some specific reasons.

The first general education class that stuck with me was MUSIC 1020 “Introduction to Music Listening”. Now it might seem strange that a low level general education course would leave such an impact on me but the way the course was taught left me with a new outlook on how to best be an engineer. The course went over several different music styles from all around the world. This opened my eyes to the fact that in life it takes many different people in many different places to solve big issues. An example of this can be seen with an engineering firm creating a product for people in an entirely different country. You need to take into account their customs and why their customs exist. This course taught me to look deeper into other cultures and to better appreciate them, something that when dealing with different groups all across the world in an engineering situation, will help me to be both understanding and knowledgeable about their needs.

The next class that stuck out to me was Criminal Justice 2400 “Introduction to the U.S. Criminal Justice System”. This class stuck out to me because of its ability to define patterns in those who commit serious, often violent, crimes. This class taught me to learn the system in order to better understand why things that happen happen. One engineering problem facing cybersecurity is ransomware attacks and specifically finding

the threat actors and bringing them to justice. This class delved into how that happens in the United States.

The final class I want to discuss is "Liberty and Law in America". This class taught me the importance of the process through its walkthrough of the history of liberty in America. Often in engineering one small problem is the focus of a group of people but the bigger picture matters far more than the engineers realize. This bigger picture thinking has helped me in my own time doing engineering projects like senior design as we face many small challenges it is easy to forget the overarching goal of the project. This class also helped me get a better perspective on issues facing our nation as a society and has provided context on those hot topic issues.

Ultimately my time at Iowa State University has left me with many lessons and many of those lessons came from my general elective courses. They have given me many opportunities to grow as a student and a person. They have also challenged my perspective on learning and given me many new skills to bring to my life once I finish college.